

Chapter 28: No More Middle Distance

Jenny started noticing something she couldn't ignore anymore.

Austin wasn't just present.

He was consistent.

That was different.

Before, his presence felt like visits.

Now it felt like a rhythm.

He came.

He stayed.

He left.

And always returned.

Like he had built his schedule around her without announcing it.

Jenny hated how natural it felt.

"Table seven," Bao called out.

Jenny didn't even look up.

"I know."

But her eyes still went there.

Automatically.

Of course they did.

Austin was already seated.

Waiting.

As always.

Except now...

He didn't look like he was waiting for permission anymore.

He looked like he was part of the space.

Jenny tightened her grip on the tray.

"That's not healthy," she muttered under her breath.

Bao leaned in immediately.

"What isn't?"

Jenny sighed.

"Nothing."

Bao smirked.

"You mean him."

"I didn't say that."

"You didn't have to."

Jenny walked away.

Faster than necessary.

Again.

When she reached his table, Austin looked up immediately.

No delay.

No hesitation.

Like she had been expected.

"You're early," he said.

"I'm not early."

"You are for your usual route."

Jenny frowned.

"...My route?"

"Yes."

She blinked.

"You're tracking my movement now?"

"I notice patterns," he corrected.

"That sounds worse."

A faint pause.

Then—

"It's not meant to."

Jenny placed the order pad down.

"You're getting too comfortable here."

Austin tilted his head slightly.

"I am comfortable here."

That made her pause.

"...That's not normal."

"It is for me."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"You don't belong here."

A beat.

Then calmly—

"I think I do."

That landed differently.

Not defensive.

Not emotional.

Just certain.

Jenny studied him.

"You used to treat this place like a temporary stop."

"I used to treat everything like that," he said.

"And now?"

Austin looked at her.

"Now I don't."

Silence.

The restaurant noise faded again in her awareness.

Jenny didn't like that feeling anymore.

Because it meant he was becoming stable in something she had not agreed was stable.

"You're changing your life around this," she said quietly.

"I'm not changing it around you," he corrected.

A pause.

"Then what is it?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"I'm building it with you in it."

That word again.

With.

Jenny felt her chest tighten slightly.

"That's a big assumption," she said.

"It's not an assumption," he replied.

"It's what I want."

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

But this time, she didn't move immediately.

Because something about the way he said it...

Didn't feel like pressure.

It felt like intention.

Later that afternoon, the restaurant slowed again.

Austin stayed longer than usual.

Jenny noticed.

Of course she did.

But now it wasn't just noticing.

It was expectation.

Like her mind had adjusted to him being part of the day's structure.

That realization unsettled her more than anything else.

Bao leaned over.

"You're thinking too hard again."

"I'm working."

"You're thinking about him again."

Jenny didn't deny it fast enough.

Bao smiled.

"You're done pretending, aren't you?"

Jenny frowned.

"I'm not pretending anything."

But her voice didn't sound convincing.

Even to herself.

When closing time came, Jenny walked over to him.

"You're still here," she said quietly.

"Yes."

She exhaled.

"You know you don't have to stay until I leave."

Austin looked up.

"I know."

"But you still do."

"Yes."

A pause.

"Why?" she asked.

Austin didn't hesitate.

"Because I like ending the day where you are."

That answer hit differently.

It wasn't dramatic.

It wasn't poetic.

It was simple.

Domestic, almost.

Jenny felt something shift in her chest.

She didn't know what to do with that.

So she defaulted to distance.

"You're going to make this harder than it needs to be."

"I don't think it needs to be easy," he said.

Jenny sighed.

"You said that before."

"I still mean it."

Silence.

Then she asked quietly,

"What happens if I don't keep up with whatever this is becoming?"

Austin stood slowly.

Not close.

Not far.

Just present.

"Then I adjust," he said.

Jenny frowned.

"That's it?"

"Yes."

"That's not how people usually do this."

"I know."

A pause.

Then softer—

"But I'm not trying to be usual."

Jenny looked at him for a long moment.

Then looked away.

Of course she did.

But this time...

She didn't tell him to stop.

She didn't tell him to leave.

She just said quietly,

"I need to lock up."

Austin nodded once.

"I'll walk you."

Jenny hesitated.

Then, quieter than before,

"...Okay."

And this time...

She didn't correct herself after saying it.

Because somehow, in the quiet rhythm of him staying...

"okay" had stopped meaning permission.

And started meaning acceptance.